

KF Introduction of NHG

Chapter 8: *The Expansive Solutions*¹

The Old Testament is full of clear examples of the neurotic expansive type. Think about Cain. He would rather kill his problem than deal with his problem. What about Pharaoh? He was terrified of the growing power of the Israelites, and to relieve his fear he dominated and sought to exterminate them. Pharaoh is a perfect example of the arrogant-vindictive type. He demands obedience and reacts aggressively when challenged. Arrogant-vindictive neurotics must always be in charge. In fact, they don't feel that they have a relationship with someone unless they can control them. It is only when they are dominating others that they feel loving, loved, and respected.

Job finds himself in the perfectionist's dilemma. He thinks that personal perfection guarantees security. In his mind, if he succeeds in living a perfect life, which for him includes offering sacrifices to cover the imperfections of his children, he can expect God's unfailing support. So, when God allows Job and his family to suffer, Job is understandably bewildered. Job's friends ostensibly come forward to comfort him, but instead of comforting him they take advantage of his vulnerability and grab the opportunity to display their superiority. Job quickly realizes that he has lost their respect.

King David is a good example of the narcissistic type. He is attractive and talented, and people love him. David is very public in his generosity and religious enthusiasm, but when someone hurts his pride, he immediately wants to kill them, or he holds on to his resentment and waits for a chance to get even. When his self-esteem is low, he reveals an immoral character; he steals and murders to get what he wants and preserve his reputation. David's pride is built on how his audience reacts to him, and he must save that pride at all costs. Without an audience, the narcissist feels that he doesn't exist.

In the temptations of Christ, we see how Satan appeals to the pride of the expansive type when he offers Jesus control over the kingdoms of the world. The desire to rule and expand kingdoms is a great temptation for expansive types. They are therefore drawn to professions or family situations where their dominance is accepted, and even required. Any kind of kingdom building opportunity is very attractive to them, especially when there are plenty of willing servants. They require everyone to recognize their superiority, and they feel rage or wrath when others will not cooperate. Expansive types need to be right. They must impose their reality on others and demand obedience or, at the very least, admiration. They want to be the ruler of the land.

Satan proposes a contract exchange; he promises to give Jesus power if Jesus will worship him. Worship means to acknowledge the excellence and authority of another. As neurotics, we are also looking for worship. We believe that if we had the power to fulfill our idealized dreams, we would be able to attract worship from others and would find self-worth in their admiration. We could even worship ourselves! Expansive types might imagine that with instant wealth and power they could effortlessly fix the world's problems, and their own, without having to patiently wait for God; they could skip the hard work of learning to trust Him. Expansive neurotics revel in challenge and conflict and feel entitled to have things go their way. They like being in charge because then, when things go well, they need only to be grateful to themselves! Jesus wisely responds to Satan with words that all neurotics need to hear: "Worship the Lord your God and serve Him only."²

Expansive types often struggle in the Karis Fellowships training. They think that they should be able to grasp everything they need to know simply by reading *Neurosis and Human Growth* and attending one or two KF meetings. They hope to use the power of their new understanding to achieve a higher level of control and impressive efficiency. They soon learn, however, that Karis Fellowships won't support this egocentric hope. Instead, KF training invites them to admit to themselves and to others that they need help and encourages them to daily examine their thoughts and behaviors. This is very painful for expansive types. However, if they endure their training with patient courage, they will learn how to redirect their unique and essential gifts toward serving their community and worshipping the one, true God.

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

² Matt. 4:10.